

What is waiting on a decision, and what is waiting on a document

Prepared 7 September 2026 by the Lunenburg Budget Project, an independent archive of the town and school budgets at lunenburgbudgetproject.org.
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The Lunenburg Budget Project — for review, 7 September 2026

6 decisions and **13 open questions**. The gap registry behind the questions holds **37 rows** across 5 kinds: `document_wanted`, `held`, `money_in`, `money_out`, `people`.

The two lists are kept apart because they behave differently, and section 3 below is the part worth reading first if you read nothing else.

1. Decisions waiting on TJ

Not questions about the data — questions about what this project should do. Nothing below is blocked on more analysis; each is blocked on somebody choosing.

#	THE DECISION	WHY IT IS YOURS AND NOT MINE	COST OF LEAVING IT
~~D1~~	~~ Push the database to D1. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — 70,013 rows in one pass; D1 verified to match the local copy, 78 tables. The plan's "140,026 writes" warning proved pessimistic: the ceiling is not rows x 2, and what exhausted the budget on 5 September was four re-imports in one day rather than the size of one.		
~~D2~~	~~ Deploy. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — v11 is live, verified against the archive manifest.		
D3	Resume the tax-rate and town-meeting extraction, or drop it. Held after repeated <code>ECONNRESET</code> . Your instruction was to hold if the agents keep failing and continue if some make progress.	The balance-sheet and special-revenue extractions since then both succeeded, so the evidence has changed.	Two datasets stay uncaptured. Nothing else depends on them.
~~D4~~	~~ What to do about athletics.md being stale. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — both analyses corrected, the page no longer disagrees, and the verifier now reads both documents and recomputes the series it had never checked.		
~~D5~~	~~ Extract the FY2024/FY2025 enterprise-only combining balance sheets. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — both years tie to their own printed PROOF; FY2024's two printings agree figure for figure. Found a \$102,000 pair of compensating errors and a published query that had never been run.		
D6	The PEG revenue-vs-expenses statements , ~11 editions with a real cross-check. Same shape of decision as D5, and the cross-check makes it the better bet of the two.	Scope.	Same.
D7	Send a records request. The gaps registry now names specific documents rather than describing absences — the FY2023 trial balance, the five athletics memos, the <code>Account_Detail</code> export for orgs S3066672/S3066671, DESE's End of Year Financial Report. That is a letter, not a list.	It is outbound, to the Town, in your name.	The gaps stay gaps. Several are load-bearing.
D8	Audit the other extracts for the parenthesised-negative defect. <code>sped_para_history</code> was wrong by \$315,772 in FY2024 — twice the line, because a sign error doubles rather than zeroes. Fixed there; not looked for elsewhere.	It is unbounded work with an unknown yield, which is exactly the kind of thing to decide rather than drift into.	Unknown. That is the argument for doing it.
D10	Whether to re-derive the model's 2% state-aid rate. It is recorded as <code>BARE</code> — no stated source, no derivation — and measured Chapter 70 receipts grew 4.47%/yr FY2014–FY2022. The two are not comparable (different quantity, different span, actual-to-actual vs forward), so this is not a bug report; it is a question about whether to go and build the comparable series.	Changing a projection rate moves every published figure downstream of it, and rule 14 says a correction that size makes <i>other</i> errors findable. That	The rate stays unsupported, and the site keeps saying so honestly. Not urgent.

is a decision with a
workload attached.

~~D11~~ ~~Fix `source_ref` in `extract_free_cash.py`.~~
DONE 7 Sep 2026 — `source_ref` now names the amount's
own cell and a new `label_ref` names the label. The extractor
re-opens the workbook and asserts every one of the 630
citations resolves to its own figure before it writes; proved it
refuses by breaking the column arithmetic by one. The free-cash
page's workaround is deleted.

D9	Whether he ld is the right fourth side in the gaps registry, alongside <code>money_in</code> , <code>money_out</code> , <code>people</code> and <code>document_wanted</code> . Added for the balance-sheet gap: money the town is holding is genuinely neither in nor out.	A taxonomy is an editorial choice and it renders on a public page.	Nothing breaks. Sides are read off the data, so changing it is a CSV edit.
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2. Open questions — the data ones

These do not resolve by choosing. Each needs a document, and each names the one that would close it. All are
registered in `sources/data/money-gaps.csv` unless marked.

Load-bearing, in the sense that other conclusions rest on them:

1. **Which fund pays which post.** The in-district special education escalator is built on a paraprofessional
line, and that line cannot be distinguished from grant money unwinding. This is the single most
consequential unknown in the project. *Closes:* DESE's End of Year Financial Report, which separates
spending by fund.
2. **Whether a general fund athletics line is net of the revolving fund.** Rule 11's problem at its
sharpest, on the one programme where both sides are visible. *Closes:* the MUNIS `Account_Detail` export
for orgs S3066672 and S3066671.

Specific and probably closeable:

1. **What the \$87,293.86 is.** Two tables in the FY2023 annual report state the same quantity and differ.
Not a misreading — the page ties to itself in all six columns. The `Sale of Cemetery Lots` explanation is
tested and dead (§4 above). *Closes:* the Town's FY2023 trial balance as of 30 June 2023.
2. **The residual \$14.23** inside that. No FY2023 fund carries it, positive or negative. Probably not
independently meaningful, but it is unexplained and unexplained is the honest word.
3. **Whether the \$87,293.86 is connected to the \$17,861.24** the town restated in grant funds between
the FY2022 and FY2023 reports. Two different amounts in the same year. *Nothing joins them* — that is a
statement about the evidence, not a denial.

4. **What the four GEN journal entries moved.** \$254,121.18 into fund 1301 in FY2025, two thirds of the year's inflow, described in the ledger only as *per memo*. *Closes:* the five memos.
5. **FY26 year-end.** Everything held for FY26 stops at 31 March.
6. **What any Cherry Sheet actually says.** We hold none, for any year — every aid figure in this project is read off a ledger, a proof workbook or a DESE file rather than off the document that states the aid. *Closes:* DLS forms CS 1-ER and CS 1-EB for Lunenburg, FY2021–FY2027.
7. **Whether an aid shortfall lands on the schools or on the town.** FY2024 came in \$390,814 under estimate. Who absorbed it is in nothing we hold. *Closes:* the fiscal-year-end recap (Form A-1), beside the Cherry Sheet.
8. **How many children Chapter 70 is paid for.** Foundation enrolment is 1,599; DESE's own measures give 1,563, 1,568.9 and 1,665.9. Four counts of four different things. *Closes:* DESE's FY27 foundation enrolment worksheet.

Bounded rather than answerable:

1. **How many children play sports.** Two town documents give 593 and 649 for the same year and count different things. No unduplicated count is published.
2. **Whether the fee rises moved participation.** Fees +30%, participations –3.9%, over exactly the same years. This is not a data gap that a document closes — it is a causal question the data cannot carry, and I do not expect it ever to. Listed so that nobody re-opens it thinking a records request would settle it.
3. **Whether a large CL#11 is prudence, a hiring freeze, a slipped project or an over-budgeted line.** Relevant to the free cash page in progress; the components do not distinguish them.

3. How to use the two lists

The distinction is the whole point of keeping them apart. **\$6 items go stale** — a decision not taken is a decision taken by default, and D1/D2 in particular decay into "the site is out of date and nobody chose that". **\$7 items do not go stale.** They are correctly parked, they are published on `/what-we-cannot-answer`, and the honest state of a \$7 item is open.

The failure mode to avoid is treating a \$7 item as if it were a \$6 one — deciding what the \$87,293.86 probably is, rather than asking for the trial balance. Rule 7 exists because that conversion happens quietly and reads like progress.

Extracted from `notes/findings/DRILL-IN-PAGES.md` sections 6-8 by `scripts/build_decisions_doc.py`. The counts above are computed at build time, and the gap count is read from `sources/data/money-gaps.csv` — so if a question here is not registered there, these two numbers stop agreeing.